# Living Well with Parkinson's: Your First Steps

A guide for people who have just been diagnosed — and for the people who care about them.

Neurology clinic

Phone: _____

Nurse / care coordinator: _____

## What Parkinson's is — in plain words

Parkinson's disease happens when a small group of brain cells that make a chemical called **dopamine** slowly stop working. Dopamine helps movements start and flow smoothly, so the most visible signs are slowness, stiffness and sometimes tremor. It can also affect sleep, mood, digestion, blood pressure and the sense of smell — these "non-movement" symptoms are just as real, and treatable too.

Three things to hold on to: **it is very treatable** — most people live well for many years; **it progresses slowly and differently in each person**, so no one can predict your course from day one; and **what you do matters** — the most powerful thing in your control is exercise.

## The most important thing you can do: move — every week, for the rest of your life

Regular, fairly vigorous exercise improves movement, balance, mood and sleep, and may slow how Parkinson's progresses. Treat it like a prescription: **about 150 minutes a week**, built up over 6–8 weeks from wherever you are now.

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| **Aerobic** | **30 minutes, 4–5 days a week.** Brisk walking, treadmill, stationary bike, elliptical, swimming. Work hard enough that talking in full sentences becomes a little difficult. |
| **Strength** | **2–3 days a week.** Legs, hips, back and shoulders — bands, light weights, or your own body weight. Stand up from a chair without using your hands, ten times. |
| **Balance & big moves** | **2–3 days a week.** Tai chi, boxing classes designed for Parkinson's, dance, or "BIG" exercises taught by a physical therapist. These train the large, confident movements Parkinson's shrinks. |
| **Stretch** | **10 minutes every day.** Stand tall against a wall, open your chest, stretch calves and hips, turn your head side to side. |

- **Join a class.** People who exercise with others keep going. Your physical therapist (every new patient is referred) will build a program around you — go even if you feel well.
- **Same time, same days** — in the calendar like an appointment; exercise when your medicine is working (about an hour after a dose).
- **Drink water** before and after; avoid the heat. **Never swim alone** — flotation vest and a watchful partner.
- **Tell us** about dizziness, falls or chest symptoms — they change the plan, they do not end it.

## If you are prescribed medicine

- **Same clock times every day.** Set phone alarms. Keep the first dose and a glass of water at the bedside; take it when you wake, before you get up.
- **Levodopa (carbidopa/levodopa, "Sinemet") works best on an empty stomach** — 30–60 minutes before a meal or an hour after. If it upsets your stomach at first, take it with a few crackers; that usually passes in a week or two.
- **Never stop it suddenly** — stopping abruptly can make you very stiff and unwell. Call us first.
- **Carry a medicine list** with clock times to every appointment and any hospital visit. **In hospital**, ask that your Parkinson's medicines be given on time, every time.
- **Tell every prescriber and pharmacist you have Parkinson's**; ask the pharmacist to check new medicines, including over-the-counter sleep or allergy pills. Nausea, vivid dreams or lightheadedness at the start are usually fixable — report them, don't quit.
- **Some medicines can make Parkinson's worse** — ask for an alternative: metoclopramide (Reglan), prochlorperazine (Compazine), promethazine (Phenergan), haloperidol (Haldol), risperidone, olanzapine, etc. This is not a complete list.

## Tell us about these — they are part of Parkinson's, and we can help

- Constipation
- Trouble sleeping, acting out dreams
- Dizziness when standing, fainting
- Low mood, worry, loss of motivation
- Memory or thinking changes
- Drooling, swallowing trouble, coughing with meals
- Falls or near-falls; feet "sticking"
- Seeing things that aren't there
- New urges — gambling, shopping, eating, sex

## Trusted places to learn more

- **Parkinson's Foundation** — parkinson.org · Helpline **1-800-4PD-INFO** (1-800-473-4636), English and Spanish, weekdays. Free "Newly Diagnosed" kit, "Aware in Care" hospital safety kit, and **PD Health @ Home** online exercise and wellness classes.
- **American Parkinson Disease Association (APDA)** — apdaparkinson.org · 1-800-223-2732. Local chapters, support groups, free booklets, and online exercise classes.
- **Davis Phinney Foundation** — davisphinneyfoundation.org. The free **"Every Victory Counts"** manual is the best single book for a new diagnosis; practical, hopeful, written with people who have Parkinson's.
- **Michael J. Fox Foundation** — michaeljfox.org. Clear guides, podcasts, and **Fox Trial Finder** if you want to take part in research.
- **PMD Alliance** — pmdalliance.org · 1-800-256-0966. Online communities, including groups for younger people and for care partners.
- **Dance for PD** — danceforparkinsons.org (free online classes). **Rock Steady Boxing** — rocksteadyboxing.org ("Find a class"). **Brian Grant Foundation** — briangrant.org (free exercise videos).

## Near you in Vermont

- **APDA Vermont Chapter** — apdaparkinson.org/vermont. Lists support groups across the state and runs a small financial-hardship fund.
- **Parkinson's Mutual Aid Group, East Montpelier** — meets the second Tuesday of each month at 2 pm in the parish house of the Old Meeting House. Open to anyone at any stage, and to family and friends. Talks on medicines, devices, and movement; a lending library.
- **Physical, occupational and speech therapy** — every newly diagnosed patient is referred to all three. Programs you may hear about: **LSVT BIG** (movement), **LSVT LOUD** (voice), **PWR! Moves**.
- **Parkinson's Programs of the Upper Valley** (Lebanon, NH area) — parkinsonsprograms.org. Rock Steady Boxing, "Staying Active" PWR! balance and strength classes, Dance for Parkinson's, Pedaling for Parkinson's.
- **Online, from home** — PD Health @ Home (Parkinson's Foundation), APDA virtual classes, Dance for PD at Home. Good for Vermont winters.
- Class times and locations change — call ahead. Updated October 2026.

## Planning ahead — things people are glad they did early

- **Name a health-care agent and write an advance directive** while it is easy. Free Vermont forms and help: **Vermont Ethics Network**, vtethicsnetwork.org (or ask our clinic for the short form); register it with the state's Advance Directive Registry.
- **Driving.** Most people with Parkinson's drive safely for years. Tell us if you have had a near-miss, feel sleepy at the wheel, or your family is worried; we can arrange a formal driving evaluation. Tell the DMV and your insurer if your state requires it.
- **Work.** Talk to us before making decisions about your job; many adjustments are possible, and the timing is yours.
- **Sick days.** Infections (even a bladder infection) can make Parkinson's symptoms temporarily much worse. Keep taking your medicines and call us.
- **Bones.** Falls and fractures are preventable: ask about a vitamin D level and a bone-density test.

## For care partners

You are part of the care team. You will often notice changes before the person does — sleep, mood, swallowing, memory, new habits — and we want to hear about them. Looking after yourself is not optional: care-partner groups (APDA, Parkinson's Foundation, PMD Alliance "Care Partners Connect") and short breaks keep you well for the long run. If you feel exhausted, low or alone, tell us.

## Bring to your next visit

- [ ] Your medicine list with clock times
- [ ] Minutes of exercise per week (a wearable or a note on the fridge)
- [ ] Two or three things you find harder than a year ago
- [ ] Questions — write them down as they come to you
- [ ] A family member or friend, if you can

## My plan

Exercise I will do this week: _____

Days / times: _____

Class or program to call: _____

Next appointment: _____

General information, not a substitute for your own care team's advice. Resources checked October 2026 — call ahead.